Updated: October 24, 2011

OFFICE OF STUDENT FINANCIAL AID
STRATEGIC PLAN

Mission

The Office of Student Financial Aid provides comprehensive financial assistance to students seeking a higher education.

Vision

The Office of Student Financial Aid will utilize continued service and technological advances to provide students every opportunity in pursuing and continuing their education while maintaining behaviors and standards of professional conduct.

Values

Based on the National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFA), the financial aid professional shall:

- Be committed to removing financial barriers for those who wish to pursue postsecondary learning.
- Make every effort to assist students with financial need.
- Be aware of the issues affecting students and advocate their interests at the institutional, state, and federal levels.
- Support efforts to encourage students, as early as the elementary grades, to aspire to and plan for education beyond high school.
- Educate students and families through quality consumer information.
- Respect the dignity and protect the privacy of students, and ensure the confidentiality of student records and personal circumstances.
- Ensure equity by applying all need analysis formulas consistently across the institution's full population of student financial aid applicants.
- Provide services that do not discriminate on the basis of race, gender, ethnicity, sexual orientation, religion, disability, age, or economic status.
- Recognize the need for professional development and continuing education opportunities.
- Promote the free expression of ideas and opinions, and foster respect for diverse viewpoints within the profession.
- Commit to the highest level of ethical behavior and refrain from conflict of interest or the perception thereof.
- Maintain the highest level of professionalism, reflecting a commitment to the goals of the National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators.

Strategic Priority 1: ***Increase Enrollment and Promote Student Success***

Outcome: We will grow and diversify our student population in order to improve higher education participation and supply a well-equipped, educated workforce for the State of Texas.

Assessment Method or Task:

- Launch of new Student Financial Aid website for concise delivery of information to students and parents.
- New liaison position for Student Financial Aid and Student Business Services fully utilized in coordination of Student Financial Aid procedures and processes as well as billing account resolution and supervisory role in call center.
- Successful loan comparison added to Student Financial Aid website for student and parents to compare terms and interest rates prior to borrowing.
- Continue a highly successful practice of staffing Senior Financial Aid Advisor in Law School.
- Continue to successfully utilize position with the responsibility to review and award TEXAS Grant and TEXAS Be-On-Time to eligible students.
- Continue to realign loan processing for ease of student process completion as well as workload process.
- Developed forms for student verification and special circumstances including working forms for advisors to file in student's imaged documents for consistency in audit and processing.
- Continue to realign loan processing for ease of student process completion as well as workload process.
- Continue to address federal loan default rates, borrower concerns and student loan indebtedness.

Result Type: Goal Met

Action Status: Action Complete

Strategic Priority 2: ***Strengthen Academic Quality and Reputation***

Outcome: We will attract and retain the best faculty in the world in order to enhance our teaching excellence and grow our number of nationally recognized programs.

Assessment Method or Task:

- Communicate types of services offered for students to strengthen bonds for utilizing services to their fullest potential.

Result Type: Goal Met

Action Status: Action Complete

Strategic Priority 3: ***Expand and Enhance Research and Creative Scholarship***

Outcome: We will significantly increase the amount of public and private research dollars in order to advance knowledge, improve the quality of life in our state and nation, and enhance the state's economy and global competitiveness.

Assessment Method or Task:

- The Office of Student Financial Aid provides comprehensive financial assistance to students seeking a higher education.

Result Type: Goal Met

Action Status: Action Complete

Strategic Priority 4: ***Further Outreach and Engagement***

Outcome: We will expand our community outreach, promote higher education, and continue to engage in partnerships in order to improve our communities and enrich their quality of life.

Assessment Method or Task:

- Addition of two additional New Student Orientation sessions, and provide an in-depth "Paying the Bill" presentation at each for students and parents.
- Provide information sessions for prospective students and parents at the semi-annual University Day.
- Provided information at six resource fairs for parents and students. Each of these events averaged more than 200 students.
- Student Financial Center was open for service the weekend that the dorms opened to allow parents and students to receive assistance from Financial Aid and the Billing office prior to parents leaving campus.
- Expand use of media including newspaper, email, and paper notification to encourage financial aid applications.
- Conduct call campaigns to freshmen and transfer students concerning financing options.
- Continue to work closely with Admissions to begin a prospective student communication flow, and encourage prospective student interest.
- Shared important dates for scholarship and financial aid applications with admissions so these could be includes on pieces sent out by admissions.
- Conduct financial aid workshops with college departments, high school counselors and area high schools to promote college accessibility.
- Conduct outreach in Dallas, Houston, San Antonio, El Paso, and surrounding areas in conjunction with Admissions.
- Participated in the Night with the Raiders and President's Receptions by providing financial aid presentations and information for resource tables.
- Support institutionally identified strategic recruitment and retention targets.

Result Type: Goal Met

Action Status: Action Complete

Strategic Priority 5: ***Increase and Maximize Resources***

Outcome: We will increase funding for scholarships, professorships, and world-class facilities, and maximize those investments through more efficient operations in order to ensure affordability for students and accountability to the State of Texas.

Assessment Method or Task:

- Recommendations submitted to Law School deans regarding early scholarship offers with consistent scholarship amounts adopted for entering class.
- Provide access to Red Raider Guarantee to incoming transfer students with an Associates degree.
- Examination of pooled merit scholarship accounts revealed that year-end donor reporting inaccurately reflected the earnings, expenditures, and students supported by merit scholarship endowments. The existence of pooled merit scholarship accounts created the reporting complexities.
- Identify funding sources, accounting practices, and funding shortfalls to determine optimum methods for student/donor matching and merit scholarship offering. It was agreed upon by representatives of Institutional Advancement, Accounting, and the TTU Scholarship Office that merit scholarship accounts should be unpooled allowing students to be directly paid from the donor's spendable account. This action would produce more transparent reporting and provide a clearer picture of the amount of institutional money that would be needed to supplement merit program endowments. This would also provide a way to match scholars to donors at a one –to-one ratio.
- Identified donor endowments at both the university and foundation whose original gifts were given to support the merit scholarship program and set up separate spendable/scholarship accounts for each one.
- Institutional Advancement committed to contacting donors whose endowment earnings were not adequate to support the award value of one merit scholar. These donors were asked to increase the value of their endowment and informed that earnings would only be spent in years where at least one student could be supported.
- Funding shortfalls were identified by the senior accountant at all levels of the merit scholarship program. Institutional funds would be needed to support approximately two thirds of the merit scholars. These funds are made available though annually budgeted transfers funded by tuition revenues.
- Implement an improved method for matching merit donors to students, and then tracking that information in Banner and the Scholarship Tracking System.
- Merit and competitive scholarships were renamed to assist recruiters in communicating the values and eligibility requirements for different levels of scholarships.
- Develop web resources for external scholarship searches to support retention of enrolled students through value-added scholarship packaging approaches.

Result Type: Goal Met

Action Status: Action Complete